

Niraparib (Zejula®)

Niraparib (Zejula®) is a cancer drug. It is used to treat cancer of the ovary, fallopian tube and peritoneum.

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Niraparib

Niraparib is also called Zejula[®]. It is a type of targeted therapy drug called a PARP inhibitor. PARPs are proteins that help damaged cells to repair themselves.

Niraparib blocks (inhibits) how PARP proteins work. Without PARP proteins, cancer cells may become too damaged to survive, and die.

Niraparib is used to treat [cancer of the ovary](#), [fallopian tube](#) and [peritoneum](#). It may sometimes be used to treat other cancers.

It is best to read this information with our general information about [targeted therapy drugs](#) and the [type of cancer](#) you have.

Your cancer team will talk to you about this treatment and its possible side effects before you agree ([consent](#)) to have treatment.

More information about this treatment

This information is correct at time of publishing. But sometimes the types of cancer this treatment is used for, or treatment side effects, may change between revision dates.

You can talk to your cancer team if you want more detailed information about this treatment. Or visit the [electronic Medicines Compendium \(eMC\)](#) website, which has patient information leaflets (PIL) for individual drugs.

How niraparib is given

Niraparib is given as tablets or capsules. This means you can take it at home. You may have it with other cancer drugs.

During a course of treatment, you will meet someone from your cancer team, such as a:

- cancer doctor
- specialist nurse
- specialist pharmacist.

This is who we mean when we mention doctor, nurse or pharmacist in this information.

During your course of treatment, you will have regular blood tests. This is to check that it is safe for you to have treatment.

You will meet with a doctor, nurse or pharmacist before you have treatment. They will talk to you about your blood results and ask how you have been feeling. If your blood results are okay, the pharmacy team will prepare your targeted therapy.

Your course of treatment

You usually keep taking niraparib for as long as it is working and any side effects can be managed. Your cancer team will discuss your treatment plan with you.

They will give you the tablets or capsules to take home. Always take them exactly as they tell you to. This is important to make sure they work as well as possible for you.

Your cancer team may also give you anti-sickness drugs and other medicines to take home. Take all your capsules or tablets exactly as they tell you to.

Taking niraparib tablets or capsules

You usually take niraparib once daily. Make sure you:

- take them 1 hour before, or 2 hours after eating, or with a light meal
- swallow them whole with a glass of water
- do not chew, open, break or crush them
- try to take them at the same time every day. If you are having nausea (feeling sick), taking them at bedtime can help.

If you forget to take the tablets or capsules, take the next dose at the scheduled time. Do not take a double dose to make up for the missed dose. You can contact the hospital on the 24-hour number you have been given for advice.

Other things to remember about your tablets or capsules:

- Keep them in the original package and at room temperature, away from moisture, heat and direct sunlight.
- Keep them safe, where children cannot see or reach them.

- If you are sick (vomit) just after taking them, do not take an extra dose. Take your next dose at the usual time.
- Do not throw away unused tablets or capsules. Return them to your cancer team at the hospital.

Lactose

This treatment may contain lactose. If you have a lactose allergy or intolerance, ask your doctor, nurse or pharmacist for more information.

Tartrazine

Niraparib capsules contain a food colouring called tartrazine (E102). If you are allergic to tartrazine, talk to your doctor before taking this treatment.

Niraparib tablets do not contain tartrazine.

About side effects

We explain the most common side effects of this treatment here. We also include some that are less common.

You may get some of the side effects we mention, but you are unlikely to get all of them. And you may have some side effects, including rarer ones, that we have not listed here.

Other cancer treatments may cause different side effects. If you are also having other cancer treatment, you may have other side effects.

Always tell your doctor, nurse or pharmacist about any side effects you have. They can give you:

- drugs to help control some side effects
- advice about managing side effects.

It is important to take any drugs exactly as explained. This means they will be more likely to work for you.

Serious and life-threatening side effects

Some cancer treatments can cause serious side effects. Sometimes, these may be life-threatening. Your doctor, nurse or pharmacist can explain the risk of these side effects to you.

Contact the hospital

Your doctor, nurse or pharmacist will give you 24-hour contact numbers for the hospital. If you feel unwell or need advice, you can call at any time of the day or night. Save these numbers in your phone or keep them somewhere safe.

Side effects while treatment is being given

Some people have side effects while taking this treatment, or shortly after.

Allergic reaction

Some people have an allergic reaction while having this treatment. Signs of a reaction can include:

- feeling hot or flushed
- shivering
- itching
- a skin rash
- feeling dizzy or sick
- a headache
- feeling breathless or wheezy
- swelling of your face or mouth
- pain in your back, tummy or chest.

If you feel unwell or have any of these signs, contact the hospital straight away on the 24-hour number. Do not take any more of this treatment until you have spoken to them.

Always call 999 if swelling happens suddenly or you are struggling to breathe.

Very common side effects

These side effects happen to 10 or more people in every 100 people (10% or more) who have this treatment.

Risk of infection

This treatment can reduce the number of white blood cells in your blood. These cells fight infection. If your white blood cell count is low, you may be more likely to get an [infection](#). A low white blood cell count is called neutropenia.

An infection can be very serious when the number of white blood cells is low. It is important to get any infection treated as soon as possible. If you have any of the following symptoms, contact the hospital straight away on the 24-hour number:

- a temperature above 37.5°C
- a temperature below 36°C
- you feel unwell, even with a normal temperature
- you have symptoms of an infection.

Symptoms of an infection include:

- feeling shivery and shaking
- a sore throat
- a cough
- breathlessness
- diarrhoea
- needing to pass urine (pee) often, or discomfort when you pass urine.

It is important to follow any specific advice your cancer treatment team gives you.

You will have regular blood tests during treatment. If your white blood cell count is low, your doctor may stop your treatment for a short time, until your cell count increases. Sometimes they will reduce the dose of your treatment.

Bruising and bleeding

This treatment can reduce the number of platelets in your blood. Platelets are cells that help the blood to clot.

If the number of platelets is low, you may bruise or bleed easily. You may have:

- nosebleeds
- bleeding gums
- heavy periods
- blood in your urine (pee) or stools (poo)
- tiny red, brown or purple spots that may look like a rash – these spots can be harder to see if you have black or brown skin.

If you have any unexplained bruising or bleeding, contact the hospital straight away on the 24-hour number. You may need a drip to give you extra platelets. This is called a platelet transfusion.

Anaemia (low number of red blood cells)

This treatment can reduce the number of red blood cells in your blood. Red blood cells carry oxygen around the body. If the number of red blood cells is low, this is called anaemia. You may feel:

- very low in energy
- breathless
- dizzy and light-headed.

If you have these symptoms, contact the hospital straight away on the 24-hour number. You may need treatment for anaemia. If you are very anaemic, you may need a drip to give you extra red blood cells. This is called a blood transfusion.

High blood pressure

This treatment may cause high blood pressure. Tell your doctor or nurse if you have ever had problems with high blood pressure, or if you take drugs for this. Your nurse will check your blood pressure regularly during treatment. Let them know if you have any headaches.

Feeling sick

This treatment can make you feel or be sick. Taking your capsules or tablets at bedtime may help [control sickness](#). Your doctor can also give you anti-sickness drugs to help prevent or control sickness. Take the drugs exactly as your nurse or pharmacist tells you.

If you feel sick, take small sips of fluids and eat small amounts often. It is important to drink enough fluids. If you continue to feel sick, or are sick (vomit) more than once in 24 hours, contact the hospital as soon as possible. They will give you advice. Your doctor or nurse may change the anti-sickness drug to one that works better for you.

Constipation

This treatment can cause [constipation](#). Constipation means that you are not able to pass stools (poo) as often as you normally do. It can become difficult or painful. Here are some tips that may help:

- Drink at least 2 litres (3½ pints) of fluids each day.
- [Eat high-fibre foods](#), such as fruit, vegetables and wholemeal bread.
- Do regular gentle exercise, like going for short walks.

If you have constipation, contact the hospital on the 24-hour number for advice. They can give you drugs called laxatives to help.

If you have not been able to pass stools for over 2 days and are being sick, contact the 24-hour number straight away.

Diarrhoea

This treatment may cause [diarrhoea](#). Diarrhoea means passing more stools (poo) than is normal for you, or having watery or loose stools. You may also have stomach cramps. If you have a stoma, it may be more active than usual.

If you are passing loose stools 3 or more times a day and this is not normal for you, contact the hospital as soon as possible on the 24-hour number. Follow the advice they give you about:

- taking anti-diarrhoea medicines
- drinking enough fluids to keep you hydrated and to replace lost salts and minerals
- any changes to your diet that might help.

They might also ask you for a specimen of your stool to check for infection.

Tummy pain

You may get pain in your tummy (abdomen), or have indigestion. Your doctor, nurse or pharmacist can give you advice or treatment to help. Contact the hospital straight away on the 24-hour number if your symptoms do not go away, or get worse.

Loss of appetite

This treatment can affect your appetite. Don't worry if you do not eat much for 1 or 2 days. But if your appetite does not come back after a few days, or if you are losing weight, tell your doctor, nurse or pharmacist. They can give you advice. They may give you food or drink supplements. Or they may suggest changes to your diet or eating habits to help.

Feeling tired

[Feeling tired](#) is a common side effect of this treatment. Try to pace yourself and plan your day so you have time to rest. Gentle exercise, like short walks, can help you feel less tired.

If you feel sleepy, do not drive or use machinery.

Difficulty sleeping (insomnia)

Sometimes this treatment can affect your sleep. Tell your doctor, nurse or pharmacist if cancer treatment makes it [difficult to sleep](#).

Dizziness

You may feel dizzy during this treatment. Tell your doctor or nurse if this is difficult to cope with. If you feel dizzy, do not drive or operate machinery.

Headaches

This treatment may cause headaches. If you have headaches, tell your doctor, nurse or pharmacist. They can give you advice about painkillers that may help. Tell them if the headache does not get better, or gets worse.

Muscle or joint pain

You may get pain in your back, or in your muscles or joints. If this happens, tell your doctor, nurse or pharmacist. They can give you painkillers and advice. They can also tell you if any of the painkillers you usually take are suitable.

Tell them if the pain does not get better. Having warm baths and resting regularly may help.

Effects on the heart

You may feel your [heart](#) is beating too fast or your heartbeat is not regular. This is a common side effect of this treatment. It is not usually serious. But you should contact your doctor straight away so they can check.

Other side effects

These side effects happen to less than 10 in 100 people (less than 10%) who have this treatment. Some of them are much rarer than this but they are still important to know about. Rare means a side effect that happens to less than 1 in 1,000 people (less than 0.1%).

Mood changes

You may feel low or depressed, or anxious. Tell your doctor, nurse or pharmacist if you feel like this. They can talk to you about different ways to manage low mood or [depression](#).

Sore mouth and throat

This treatment may cause a [sore mouth and throat](#). You may also get mouth ulcers. This can make you more likely to get a mouth or throat infection. Use a soft toothbrush to clean your teeth or dentures in the morning, at night and after meals.

Contact the hospital straight away on the 24-hour number, if:

- a sore mouth or throat affects how much you can drink or eat
- your mouth, tongue, throat or lips have any blisters, ulcers or white patches.

They can give you advice, and mouthwash or medicines to help with the pain or to treat any infection. Follow their advice and make sure you:

- drink plenty of fluids
- avoid alcohol and tobacco
- avoid food or drinks that irritate your mouth and throat.

Changes to your taste

Some foods may taste different or have no taste. Try different foods to find out what tastes best to you. You may also get a bitter or metallic taste in your mouth. Your doctor, nurse or pharmacist can give you advice. It might help to try:

- sucking sugar-free sour or boiled sweets
- eating cold foods
- eating sharp-tasting fresh fruit.

We have more information about [coping with changes to taste](#).

Fluid build-up

This treatment can cause a build-up of fluid in the body. Contact the hospital on the 24-hour number if you:

- are gaining weight
- have swelling in your face, legs or ankles.

They can give you advice and treatment to help.

Skin changes

This treatment can affect your skin. If your skin feels dry, try using soap-free cleansers and unperfumed moisturising cream every day.

This treatment can also:

-

cause a rash, which may be itchy

- make you more sensitive to the sun.

Your skin may burn more easily during treatment and for several months after. Use a sun cream of at least SPF 30. SPF stands for sun protection factor. Cover up with clothing and wear a hat.

Always tell your doctor, nurse or pharmacist about any [skin changes](#). They can give you advice or prescribe creams or medicines to help. Changes to your skin are usually temporary and improve when treatment ends.

Effects on the eyes

Your eyes may become watery and feel sore. Your doctor, nurse or pharmacist can give you advice and eye drops to help with this.

Contact the hospital on the 24-hour number if:

- your eyes get red and inflamed (conjunctivitis)
- you have pain in your eyes
- you notice any change in your vision.

Memory and concentration

You may notice [changes in your memory](#). You may also find it harder to concentrate.

To help you remember things, try using:

- reminder alarms or notes on your phone
- a diary, calendar or phone app
- a notebook you carry with you.

Effects on the lungs

This treatment can cause changes to the lungs. Tell your doctor, nurse or pharmacist if you develop:

- a cough that does not go away
- wheezing
- breathlessness.

You should also tell them if any existing breathing problems get worse. You may have tests to check your lungs.

Second cancer

This treatment can increase the risk of developing a type of blood cancer. The benefits of treatment usually far outweigh this risk. Your doctor, nurse or pharmacist can give you more information.

Effects on the brain

Rarely, this treatment causes a brain condition that can be serious. You can make a full recovery from this. But it must be diagnosed and treated quickly.

This condition can cause:

- a headache that does not get better
- drowsiness or confusion
- changes in eyesight
- fits (seizures).

If you have any of these symptoms, it is important to either:

- contact the hospital straight away on the 24-hour number
- go to the hospital straight away.

You should not drive yourself to hospital.

Other information

Blood clot risk

Cancer and some cancer treatments can increase the risk of a [blood clot](#). Contact the hospital straight away on the 24-hour number if you have any of these symptoms during or after treatment:

- throbbing pain or swelling in a leg or arm
- reddening of the skin in the area – if you have black or brown skin, this can be harder to notice, but the skin might become darker
- suddenly feeling breathless or coughing.

Always call **999** if you have:

- chest pain
- difficulty breathing.

A blood clot is serious, but it can be treated with drugs called anticoagulants. These thin the blood. Your doctor, nurse or pharmacist can give you more information about preventing and treating blood clots.

Other medicines

Some medicines can affect how this treatment works or be harmful while you are having it. Always tell your cancer doctor, nurse or pharmacist about any drugs you are taking or planning to take, such as:

- medicines you have been prescribed
- medicines you buy in a shop, pharmacy or online
- vitamins or supplements
- [herbal drugs and complementary or homeopathic therapies](#)
- recreational drugs – for example, cannabis.

Vaccinations

Cancer doctors usually recommend that people with cancer have vaccinations for flu and [coronavirus \(covid\)](#). They may also recommend other vaccines, such as Shingrix[®] for shingles. These all help reduce your risk of serious illness from these infections. Most people can have these vaccines, including people with weak immune systems.

You should not have live vaccines if your immune system is weak. This includes if you are having or recently had chemotherapy, radiotherapy or other cancer treatments that affect your immune system. Live vaccines can make you unwell because they contain a very weak version of the illness they protect you against. There are several live vaccines, including the yellow fever vaccine.

It is important to ask your doctor, nurse or pharmacist for advice about having vaccinations. They can explain what vaccines are right for you and when it is best to have them.

Contraception

Your doctor, nurse or pharmacist will advise you not to [get pregnant](#) or [make someone pregnant](#) while having this treatment and for some time afterwards. The drugs may harm a developing baby. It is important to use contraception to prevent pregnancy. Follow their advice about:

- what types of contraception to use
- how long after treatment you should continue to use contraception.

Breastfeeding

You are advised not to [breastfeed](#) while having this treatment, or for some time after treatment ends. This is because the drugs could be passed to the baby through breast milk.

Your doctor, nurse or pharmacist can give you more information.

Fertility

Some cancer drugs can affect whether you can [get pregnant](#) or [make someone pregnant](#). If you are worried about this, it is important to talk with your doctor before you start treatment.

Medical and dental treatment

If you need medical treatment for any reason other than cancer, always tell the healthcare professional that you are having cancer treatment. Give them the contact details for your cancer doctor or cancer team so they can ask for advice.

If you have appointments with a dentist, always tell them you are having cancer treatment. Talk to your cancer team before you have any dental treatment.

About our information

This information has been written, revised and edited by Macmillan Cancer Support's Cancer Information Development team. It has been reviewed by expert medical and health professionals and people living with cancer.

References



Visit the [electronic Medicines Compendium \(eMC\)](#) to download a Patient Information Leaflet (PIL) for more detailed information. The leaflet lists all known side effects.

[Cancer Information Development team](#)

Author

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Our cancer information meets the [PIF TICK](#) quality mark.

This means it is easy to use, up-to-date and based on the latest evidence. Learn more about [how we produce our information](#).

The language we use

We want everyone affected by cancer to feel our information is written for them.

We want our information to be as clear as possible. To do this, we try to:

- use plain English
- explain medical words
- use short sentences
- use illustrations to explain text
- structure the information clearly
- make sure important points are clear.

We use gender-inclusive language and talk to our readers as 'you' so that everyone feels included. Where clinically necessary we use the terms 'men' and 'women' or 'male' and 'female'. For example, we do so when talking about parts of the body or mentioning statistics or research about who is affected.

You can read more about how we produce our information [here](#).

How we can help

How to print a PDF from this website

Instructions on how you can make a PDF version of this page using the print function on your browser.

Clinical Information Nurse Specialists

Our Cancer Information Nurse Specialists are dedicated cancer nurses available to talk to on our Macmillan Cancer Support Line.



Call us free on 0808 808 0000

8am to 8pm, 7 days a week. You can talk to our cancer specialists about anything.



Email the Macmillan Support Line

Email the Macmillan Support Team if you have any questions.

Chat online

Available 8am to 7.45pm, 7 days a week. For confidential, real-time support if you don't want to call.



Online Community

Chat online anonymously to others who understand what you are going through. Our community is available 24/7 and has dedicated forums where you can get advice and ask our experts.



Find cancer support services in your area

What's going on near you? Find out about support groups, where to get information and how to get involved with Macmillan where you live.

[Get help](#)